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Hal Galper

Pianist Hal Galper has led a diverse as a leader of his own trios, a sideman with Phil Woods and Cannonball Adderley, and as an accompanist to Joe Williams and Anita O'Day. He is a prolific composer and an in-demand jazz clinician.

Hal was interviewed via Zoom on June 27, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm really pleased to have Hal Galper with me this afternoon. And I recall you made a point that you don't sort of come alive until the afternoon. After years of the jazz life.

HG: Sixty years of the jazz life. My circadian rhythm is set. Try as I might I still end up going to bed 3:33 every morning. It cuts down my daytime but you know I'm a night person. What can I tell you.

MR: Yeah. It's okay with me. I'm not that much of a night person but I still — my circadian rhythm still goes to about midnight. I wanted to ask you, you were born in 1938, is that correct?

HG: Correct.

MR: So if you could think back to let's say 1950 and the pop music or the music that was likely to be heard on the radio went really wide variety of things. A little big band left over, Mitch Miller, Frank Sinatra.

HG: Rhythm and blues. In the early 50s I was dancing to that music.

MR: Well that's sort of my question. What was it that appealed to you that you heard on the radio and might make you go out and buy a record at 10 or 12 years old.

HG: Well I didn't really hear jazz on the radio. I didn't listen to the radio at that age. My brother, older brother, was a waiter at a camp in Western Massachusetts one summer and he stole the George Shearing album, without the cover, and brought it back to me, thinking I would enjoy it. That's the first jazz I ever heard. It was called "Changing With the Times." And there was that tune on "Changing With the Times" was on there. I knew when I got the record, I thought this is it. I knew — I recognized this is what I wanted to do. And I tried to copy "Changing With the Times" with the miserable lack of musical knowledge I had at the time, which was I could just about play in the key of C a little bit and maybe even a little bit less in C minor. I knew nothing about four bar phrases or form or anything like that. I just couldn't get it. So many years later I'm with Phil's [Woods] band and we're touring Japan and George is on the tour with Neil Swainson playing bass.

"George," I went up and I told him I says, "you're the cause I'm here today" you know because your record was the first record, jazz record I ever heard. As a matter of fact, well I'll tell you more about that later. So I says, "George, there was a tune on that record called 'Changing With the Times' that I tried to copy and I never could get it." He said, "Well, Hal," he says, "boy that's a long time ago" he says, "give me a couple of days to think about it" you know. I said okay. So we were in a different place doing concerts, a tour, three days later I get a message before the sound check, "George wants to see you onstage." I knew what it was so I went to Jill Goodwin and I borrowed a tape recorder, and George was at the piano and he played it for me. I thought it was in E flat, it turns out my turntable was a little off and it was actually in E major. Oh my God. And he played it, he showed me every chord voicing note by note, every phrasing, it's in bars of 3/4, 4/4, and 5/4, that's why it's called "Changing With the Times" and he played a beautiful — he did the melody and chorus and then played two choruses of the most incredible improvisation. I have it on tape. It's just amazing.

MR: How would you like to share that?

HG: Huh?

MR: How would you like to share that tape?

HG: What do you mean?

MR: Well we collect things you know, and we have some George Shearing things. I'm just making a joke really. But that's a great story. And a key of E. You can play jazz for years and never play a song in the key of E.

HG: Exactly. But he was such a trained pianist you know, he just had, he was a master on the piano and he could do whatever he wanted you know. And then just recently my old lady who has opened up a vintage vinyl store found that record. I have it up now framed next to my piano, the record that got me started, "Changing With the Times" — Margie — who was it, Chuck Wayne, Margie Hyams, that band.

MR: Yeah. Oh that's a great circle of life sort of story.

HG: Yeah I like to do that. I like to closes those circles.

5:29

MR: I'm going to pause for one second and turn off a fan. Don't go anywhere.

[blows nose]

5:47

MR: So from that experience did you — I mean how old were you when you said that's it. That's what I want to do?

HG: Maybe about — you know I had taken classical piano. My mother made me take classical piano when I was younger. And I really didn't take to it. My piano teacher was always

And I tried — I convinced her to get me a popular piano teacher for a couple of lessons and boy my mom could not stand him at all. He smoked cigarettes and he had plaid jackets and you know, he didn't wear a tie and all that stuff. He's just not proper for a young man to have as a teacher. So that was it. And then I played guitar for a while while I was in my early teens, and then that record came probably the year before I graduated or two years before I graduated. Yeah. Sometimes I get off track. I have a short term memory problem, so if I do you have to bring me back.

MR: Right.

HG: Where was I?

MR: You were talking about switching to a piano teacher.

HG: Oh yeah, right. So then the last year of high school — the sophomore year of high school they thought — I was getting D's and F's through everything through school. But I had a talent for mechanical stuff and I was in an electrical course the second year of high school. I did great. The third year they thought I would be an engineer or a scientist so they sent me to this scientific prep school in Copley Square in Boston not realizing that The Stables was right across the street. And at lunchtime, I mean I was a fish out of water. All these kids had suits and ties on and everything and I'm still in my leather vest and jeans you know. But lunchtime I'd go over to The Stables and I'd hear, you know Herb Pomeroy's band rehearsing, Serge Chaloff, Dick Twardzik. And I took a couple of bongo lessons with the janitor you know. Well at the end of that year, you know I failed so miserably at the school I went back to my senior year in high school and spent most of it in the back room of the music room. And there was a great music director, Mr. DeVoe, I'll never forget him. I hardly went to class at all the senior year because I was in his back room with my trio, with a girl bass player from Tennessee and a drummer named John Frayas jamming in my naivete and you know, lack of knowledge. And he'd write me excuses to get out. He'd say I was working on the Senior Revue.

MR: Oh I have to make sure we spell this man's name right, 'cause he's important.

HG: D-E capital V-O-E.

MR: Okay.

HG: Mr. DeVoe. And he was so encouraging. He knew I had a passion for it and he encouraged it, you know, and he'd give me the — he'd sign a pass for me saying, and I actually did play on the Senior Revue, I did two songs which was total head-scratching to the audience. Not only did I not know what I was doing, they certainly didn't know what I was doing. And that was my first public performance you know.

MR: I want to talk about that for a minute, that idea that you don't know what you're doing. But you're doing it. So did there come a time after that where you started to either study

or be informed by somebody, and then you say to yourself, oh, that's what I was doing. What I was doing has a name, has chord structures, etcetera.

HG: Not until I went to Berklee. The last year of high school there was a thing in Massachusetts at the time, a State Rehabilitation Board which went around to all the high schools. They would support/help people who were disabled. And since I had one eye I qualified for a scholarship to Berklee. And my parents were not going to pay for it. So, but I took it and when it came time to graduate I got called down to the office because I wasn't doing my work, you know. And they said, "Look, you're not going to graduate if you don't study." I says, "I could care less. I'm going to Berklee. I don't need your god damn piece of paper." I didn't go to graduation or anything like that you know. And then I started at Berklee and that's when I realized how ignorant I was, and naïve when I started Berklee. Because I knew nothing. Nothing.

MR: What were your parents thinking at the time — like what is it with our son?

HG: That generation was a holdover from the Second World War where everybody had a piano and everybody had their kids learn music because it was good for brain growth and all that stuff. You know everybody had a piano in their house in those old days, an upright you know. Those days are gone.

MR: Replaced by things that may or may not develop the brain. What's your opinion on that?

HG: I'm not so sure I understand the question.

MR: I'm not sure I understand my question either. The things that students do now, videogames or tasks on the computer that may develop different parts of their brains but perhaps not the hearing that you developed.

HG: Of course. Yes. Because it's all about — all practicing is ear training and all performance is playing by ear. Period.

MR: It's a delicious bit of irony that your first classical teacher was aggravated.

HG: Yes. She'd be in the kitchen and I'd be playing a piece from memory and she could tell because I was playing with feeling and she'd yell from the kitchen "Harold, you're playing by ear." She could always tell. Mrs. Olivia was a pain the butt. A hard driver.

MR: Yeah. All right. So I'm going to jump ahead just a little bit. You get to Berklee in its early years, was it an accredited school at the time or just a —

HG: It was a college.

MR: It was a college. And was it a degree program for you?

HG: No.

MR: Okay.

HG: I didn't stay long enough to graduate. I graduated much later, many years later. It's a long story but Berklee never recognized my contributions. And I'd been noticing at the time

recommending the school. I thought gee, what about me? You know? So I called up the school and the music department said, "Well you have to finish your courses." I said, "Well I've got a hundred recordings out you know, how many more do I need to get a degree you know?" So the guy, the head of the department, said, "Why don't you talk to Herb." So I called Herb and Herb set me up with what they call a star — what do they call it, hold on, an "Artist's Diploma" which means you finished school in two years. So he gave me that without me having to graduate.

MR: Ah, how nice.

HG: And the next month they discontinued their ads.

MR: All right. So how did you become the house pianist at that club in Boston?

HG: Oh I was house pianist — eventually I was house pianist in a lot of the gigs in Boston. You mean at Lennie's?

MR: Yes.

HG: Well you know, as I went through the scene you know I have to digress for a minute so you pull me back. I'm doing a lot of legacy work now with digitizing a lot of bootleg records. And I have my career, my musical growth, from 1962 up through the 90s, digitized. Maybe even more than that. And I thought it took me a much longer time to get my stuff together in Boston. I went to Berklee and started in '56, '57, went through the summer of '57, left in '58. By '62 I had all the best gigs in town. I thought it took me much longer than that but basically within five years of starting at Berklee I had my teacher's gig. J. Ray Santisi's gig. And when I was going to that school in Copley Square I took a couple of lessons with Ray and at the second lesson he wrote out "Moonlight in Vermont" chords and melody. The next lesson, I couldn't read, I didn't know what this stuff meant. He said, "Forget it kid, you'll never play."

MR: This is Ray who now?

HG: Ray Santisi.

MR: Okay.

HG: My mentor in Boston. He died. Well wouldn't you know in 1962 I was playing Monday nights with the hippest band in town, Tuesdays and Thursdays with Herb's big band, and the rest of the week with the Herb's small group. I had this guy's job. And I totally forgot, he said that to me. Because one night he came up to me and he said, "Hal, do you remember what I told you on your second lesson?" I said no. "I told you 'forget it kid, you'll never play.'" He had no attitudes about it at all, he was just a great guy. But I learned a lesson from that too, never prejudge a student, you just never know. You never know.

MR: So if you're in a house band and let's say any number of tenor players are coming into town, Johnny Griffin, anybody like that, and you're on the bandstand and they call a tune and you don't know it, what happens then?

HG: Fake it, kid.

MR: All right. Do you hope that the bass player knows it?

HG: That's right, except on those gigs that were tenor, piano and drums. Those were — in those days I used to take my fake books with me to all the gigs because I didn't know the tunes, but they would never give you a chance to turn the page to get it. They'd say, "Forget it, kid, fake it" you know. So after two or three choruses if there was someone else playing the changes I could learn the song you know. But basic "fake it, kid" was the words I heard the most when I was young. And frankly, that's the process anyway.

MR: I was going to ask if that's a lost —

HG: I'm faking it now.

MR: Yeah.

HG: I've been faking it for 60 years. When I started you could tell I was faking it. Now I've gotten really good at it. You know? So you can't tell. Sounds like I know what I'm doing.

MR: Well I hope I do as well. You know you made a statement on one of the videos I watched recently and I couldn't tell if your tongue was in your cheek or not. You said, "It doesn't take an intelligent person to be a jazz musician."

HG: That's right. There's plenty of proof of that around.

MR: But I think also the point that you made afterwards is that over-thinking things is not helpful.

HG: Shutting down the frontal cortex.

MR: Shutting down the frontal cortex.

HG: There's a neurological pathway from the ear to the auditory section through the auditory section down to our alligator part of the brain, which is where all this stuff happens. It directly bypasses the frontal lobes. You can shut down the frontal lobes so that the music bypasses it and goes directly to the limbic system, which is where these billionth of a second decisions are made about what the next note is. You know? That's —

MR: You read a book that set you on this path, did you not?

HG: Yes. And it's interesting because in my first year at Berklee there were two things that preoccupied my mind and you have to understand I was totally naïve and totally ignorant of any musical knowledge. Two questions: what am I supposed to be feeling inside of me when I play? And, what is the nature of 1, the first beat of the bar? For some reason I had those two questions when I knew nothing. And those two questions have led me through everything that I've written and discovered about teaching and what the process is. The

when Madam Chaloff, my technique teacher, I was working on a Bach piece and she made a phrases mark of an eighth note line starting on the second eighth note of the bar, going to the first eighth note to the next. A pencil marking, a phrase mark. When I saw that and everything moved towards the last note, that was the beginning of forward motion.

MR: Did it have something to do with thinking that visual bar lines had some significance in organizing the music?

HG: What do you mean by visual bar lines?

MR: I mean like literally on the page, every four beats or every three beats you have a bar line, like a physical separation of the music. And it sounds to me like her demonstration of how one thing flowed over into the next measure — at least that's what I'm getting out of your —

HG: Well everything is in motion towards points in the future. Things are not where they are, things are where they're going.

MR: You're very quotable, Hal. Well how about this emotion while you're playing? There's been times people ask me, I've heard the question and asked of others also, what are you feeling when you play?

HG: As little as possible. I'm trying to damp down my emotional content as much as possible. You can't kill it, you'd have to kill yourself to not feel anything, but you have to — listen, the brain is trainable, the body is trainable, your emotions are trainable. And if I had to find one word that would describe, probably my growth as a musician, it would be control. It's all about control factors. And controlling training your brain, training your emotions, controlling your emotions, controlling your body. Some people disagree with me. Some people think you need the emotion. But that's incorrect. You don't need to make up — if you can swing you don't need to make anything up. So the question is if you can swing or not. And then you have to come up with the definition of what is swing that is universal. And my definition of swing is if your playing has an emotional quality to it you can swing. If your playing has an emotional quality to it, not if YOU have an emotional quality. If your playing draws you into it, has an emotional quality.

MR: Okay I need you to —

HG: I come from the 50s. You've got to be cool. I'm really beat. I'm not a hippie, I'm really beat. You've got to be cool.

MR: All right. Gary Smulyan, who told me jazz is four things and among the four things he said can you play what you feel. How does that strike you?

HG: Vague. Yeah you play what you feel. You play — Sam Rivers told me, he says, "Sometimes I improvise just using my mind, not what I hear, sometimes I improvise

automatically without thinking about it. You know? Sometimes I improvise while thinking about it."

MR: Okay so you're separating your ear from your mind. Is that a fair statement?

HG: It's mind, body, and emotions. Mind, body and emotions. Those are the tools, and the intuition. Those are the tools we use. We are the instrument, the artist themself is the instrument. We're working on internal process. That's the second question I had when I was at Berklee. What's supposed to be going on inside me when I'm playing? And that's what I spent most of my career figuring out.

MR: Did you have any epiphanies along the way with this question?

HG: Countless. That's what led me to forward motion but it took me a long time to realize that was what I was interested in. I've been working on a new book which I'm probably never going to finish, of essays. And one of the essays is on — oh shit what was I talking about? Sorry.

MR: Epiphanies and mind and ear, and the first beat.

HG: Oh all right. So I am working on one of these articles. I have a theory about how musical decisions are made. Generally most decisions are made below the level of consciousness anyway. Right? So [damn it Hal, get back] where was I? You're going to have to —

MR: Well we were talking about the first beat, and you were talking about how most decisions seem to be made in the subconscious perhaps?

HG: Yes.

MR: While you're playing?

HG: Yeah. But I have a theory about how musical growth occurs. That's what it was. Because when you listen to somebody the assumption has been that you're trying to learn something from that musician. If you're attracted to a musician that's because I feel like you have to learn there's something about that musician that is attracting you to him. So I have a belief that you're born with neutral — a whole bunch of neutral neurological neurons waiting to be stimulated from the environment. It's a thing of like the environment stimulates the growth of these neurons. When I heard that George Shearing record that lit up those neurons. They were waiting there to get lit up. All right? Let me give you a case in point. I had a band with an alto player and he played beautifully, a beautiful young, one of my top ex-students. But for years I've been trying to get him to emote more, to articulate larger than life, to, you know, get his metal buzzing and all that stuff. I was constantly on his case and he just never got it together. So the band was over a couple of years and we still communicate all the time with my ex-students. And he said, "Oh Hal, I'm going to Spain, I've got this contest in Spain that I'm going to go to, and you have to pick somebody's solo to memorize and play it." So he picked Mike Brecker's

right? He went to the festival, he came back, he said, "Well I didn't win." I said, "Well play something for me." You know. When he played he had everything I had been trying to get out of him for years. So how did that happen? Why did he pick Michael Brecker? Because Michael Brecker set off a particular neural neuron, right, that led him to pick Michael Brecker. Because that's what he needed at that moment was to copy Michael Brecker and learn how to play with that level of intensity. Because he came back from Spain a different horn player. It's out of our hands. You're not trying to learn something from the artist you're copying, the artist is trying to teach you something about yourself which is how you hear. And you have a resonance with these neurons, they're just waiting for the environment — it's a combination of preset and environment you know. That's nothing new you know. It's not a new concept.

MR: My neurons are spinning, Hal. But it leads me to a guy that made literally — did that for me, and it was Cannonball Adderley. And I remember, I guess I was 15 or 16 but that's what happened to me. I never put that description to it but that's exactly what it was.

HG: Yeah. You become attracted.

MR: Your two years — it was just two years I guess.

HG: Two and a half years it was.

MR: Two and a half years — how did they — did they invite you to contribute to the band's repertoire or did you lobby, like hey guys I have some tunes can we read them?

HG: Yeah. They always needed tunes, they always needed music, but they always had piano players that wrote.

MR: That's true.

HG: Yeah. Almost always. I don't think Junior Mance wrote but I'm not sure about that. Bobby Timmons wrote for them, you know. But I think I made him — I've said this before — I think I made a mistake in judgment in the tunes that I gave the band because I was — this is really hard to explain but I'm a greedy son of a bitch. I just want to play as much as possible because I know that school you know. But I gave them — my tunes were too modern. I mean I've got — Cannonball could play anything and Nat could play anything but it was basically a blues band and I should have stuck both solo-wise and in the tunes I gave him I think I made a mistake. Now that I can look back at my career and I have all his recordings, I can make judgments about my judgments. You know? That was a mistake. I should have stayed more blues oriented.

MR: Okay. Well I have something — you want to play a little name that tune?

HG: Sure.

MR: Okay. This is from that era, I'm going to see if I can pull this off and you tell me what it is [plays saxophone]

MR: Oh you got it. We can move on.

HG: It was my tune.

MR: It is your tune. Now just to make sure is it "Snake IN the Grass," or is it "Snakin' the Grass?"

HG: "Snake IN the grass."

MR: Okay. Well the LP —

HG: It was supposed to be snake in the burbs.

MR: The LP is a little incorrect. But I think I know what you're saying because as I listen to Cannonball over the years when it got to that point it sounded to me like they were trying to join in to the fusion thing. And I always wondered was that a conscious decision? Did Cannon and Nat like sit down and have coffee and say this is where we've got to go if we want to keep making records, or was that not the case?

HG: I couldn't say anything. I don't think I have an opinion about that. Because they were the first ones to use the Fender Rhodes. My piano was directly from Harry Rhodes' factory. I think the move to the Fender Rhodes was the key to getting into the more fusion kind of thing. Yeah.

MR: You weren't that fond of it, is that correct?

HG: My first two albums were fusion.

MR: Yes.

HG: "All Bird" was a fusion album.

MR: Right. And the Guerilla Band — I guess what made me say that is this little book here. Did you ever see this one? It's a biodiscography of Cannonball and there's a quote here from you that I guess appeared in *DownBeat* after you left the group. "I had pure joy, I wheeled the electric piano down in its case, tossed it in the Hudson River and watched the bubbles come up."

HG: Yes. I guess I have a tendency to the grand gesture. You know. It was a grand gesture. I, after much thought, realized — and then Cannon kept trying to get me to play the acoustic piano and I wouldn't do it.

MR: Oh I'm glad you said that.

HG: Because I was very insecure with the acoustic piano. It's probably a very weak point for me. And I could do what I needed to do on the electric piano but I couldn't do it on the acoustic. And when I realized that, you know, it wasn't the acoustic piano that was the problem it was I really had to do the work to get the piano together and I needed to make a commitment, you know, to acoustic piano, and that was my grand gesture. I wheeled it down to the river and threw it in. And since then I haven't played an electric keyboard. I had to do the work to get out of the piano what I wanted to get out of it. I was just

MR: Was there any advantage with the Rhodes that at least you could compete volume-wise in some situations?

HG: I don't think it made a difference. Usually on that level of playing the stages are pretty well set up. I never had a problem with that. Yeah.

[36:01]

MR: What was Cannonball like as a boss? Or was Nat the boss?

HG: Are you interviewing me or Cannonball?

MR: No I just wondered.

HG: I get this all the time. Everybody wants to know what it was like to play with this guy or to play with that guy, and eventually I begin to wonder well who are you interviewing?

MR: Okay. When you — after disposing of the Rhodes and you went back to a piano trio, did you have a different way of composing from before the experience, those two years? Did you sit and compose in a different way?

HG: I don't compose deliberately. It has to be an accident. I don't force it. I love my intuition telling me what to do. If my intuition has a tune it'll come up. I've got a tune I've been working on, fragments, gorgeous fragments, I've been trying to finish for a couple of years. Last night I was working on it and very frustrated. I couldn't hear — I have found a resolution for it but I couldn't find the notes. Just — it varies. Tunes are different animals. There are no two that are the same. You know, usually I wrote tunes to solve a problem, a musical problem. And I started a band. I started a lot of my bands for that reason because the apprenticeship system was going down the drain and I needed to play with really good people and keep playing you know, to keep my chops up and to keep growing. So quite often my bands and my writing were solutions to problem, musical problems. You know? If I was working on a new concept I would start a band, write the music for that concept that forced me to be in that concept and learn how to play in it, and that's what happened with pentatonics you know? And cells you know. I just made myself a situation where I had to play that way. And I got it together. It took me fifteen years to get pentatonics together, and ten years to get cells together.

MR: When you're working on a composition over a length of time can I envision sheets of score paper with lines written out in chord symbols or is that not the way you work?

HG: Melody first. I used to write harmony first but the melodies just came out very stilted. You have to do melody first. Once you've got the melody then I use something called good note theory, you know, which is: is this note going to be a natural 9 or a flat 9 or is it going to be a fifth of a chord. You know. So I will try it as different functions of different chords to see which sound I was looking for. Look I studied Schillinger so I have an analytical mind. You know. I took Schillinger for two years, that left me with the

you know, because I had Schillinger. And that was a major, the two most important classes were that class and Bob Sher's re-harmonization class which was re-harmonizing the American songbook from the ukulele changes into jazz changes. Fabulous course. I took to that like a duck to water. My nickname in Boston eventually was the "change master." Because I could put changes to anything.

MR: You just said a word that I didn't get. The something changes instead of the jazz changes. Talking about the Broadway tunes.

HG: Oh they were ukulele or guitar changes.

MR: Oh ukulele. Okay.

HG: He had the early fake books which were the pictures of the Library of Congress cards. And that's what we were working — this is pre *Real Book*, right? Where you had to buy the books surreptitiously, it was illegal to sell the book. You had to go to the black market to get the book you know. So and everybody is afraid they're going to get arrested because they're buying this book illegally. It's hilarious. But and that was an amazing class, Bob Sher, who is also from my hometown, would sit at the piano and show you how to reharmonize these guitar symbols into chords and sing along these inane melodies with the changes you know. We used to call it Bob Sher's cocktail hour because he'd sing along with the re-harms, you know?

MR: I see.

HG: Show how they work. Most valuable. That one and Schillinger. And it wasn't 'til many years later I realized how much Schillinger had affected my outlook, my general outlook on things. That there were reasons why things sounded good and reasons why they didn't. And that's what I wanted to find out: why things sounded good.

MR: How much weight, when you're re-harmonizing tunes, do the melody notes or note have in your choice of a chord to put with it?

HG: Oh I just mentioned it. I can consider a note any function of a chord.

MR: I see.

HG: If I wanted to I could harmonize a melody all with sharp 9s on a dominant chord. Constant harmony it's called. Or I could make them all sharp 11s. Or I could make them all thirds or fifths or ninths. That's good note theory. Does this note sound good as a nine or a sharp nine or a sharp eleven, you play it over and over and over until the vibe gets to you and tells you what is the choice. The choices are all intuitive. This is not frontal lobe. You've just got to bang away at it until the message bubbles up from way down deep below in your early brain that this is the one that works you know.

MR: So how does your trio bass player learn some of these re-harmonized tunes? Do you write a chord chart for him?

MR: You don't bring it to what?

HG: You don't bring any paper to the bandstand.

MR: Oh.

HG: Not good. It doesn't look good. You've got to get it memorized. And Tony [Marino], Tony has, I've been playing with Tony for decades. He's a consum — he's a symphony master bassist. It doesn't make any — I can get lost and he'll just follow me. It doesn't make any difference to him or to me, whichever way we go Tony is going to be there. It just never fails. He'll just go — like I said I have a short term memory problem. Sometimes, like this Saturday we were playing a song and I got distracted and I totally lost the key center in the song. I didn't — Tony was soloing and I didn't know what tune we were playing or what key we were in, couldn't tell. So that's — hey welcome to being 84 you know. But luckily it doesn't happen too much. It happens mostly when I'm talking you know. But Tony and Billy [Mintz], they just follow me anywhere I go. It doesn't make any difference what I do they just follow me. They're great. And it was the same way with Jeff Johnson and John Bishop. They were really crazy enough to follow me.

MR: I wonder if they're thinking how are we going to get out of this now. How is this going to resolve itself.

HG: You're not thinking.

MR: Okay. They're not thinking.

HG: Thinking is no good. Thinking doesn't work. Thinking is slow. The only thing that could make the decisions about note choice is the limbic system. Down there decisions are made almost at the speed of light. And you're not even aware of it. I trust my intuition a hell of a lot more than my intellect. A hell of a lot more. It's never wrong. Never. You know when you're leaving the house and your intuition tells you — and it's sunny outside and your intuition tells you I should bring an umbrella out. Something pops up from real deep down below because your body is an antenna and it's monitoring the environment 24/7 okay. It's picked some kind of information, maybe a slight change upwards in humidity or something that you didn't notice, but it's beautiful sunlight outside and you say naa, I don't need it. And you get out there and next thing you know you're in a rainstorm. It's never wrong, your intuition. Never. But you have to trust it. That's the tool we use. That's one of the things we are training as we learn how to play is our intuition. It never is never wrong.

MR: Does that concept, this is a bit of a tangent but — apply to when it comes to put a title on one of your compositions? Where do your song titles come from?

HG: Usually a personal experience. Sometimes a personal experience. Sometimes it's just

MR: Yeah I was listening to you play I think it's "Waiting for Chet." "Waiting for Chet."

HG: Well that's a story.

MR: And I was trying to tell if the beginning, you were playing by yourself I think. If the bass player was there I couldn't hear it 'cause of the recording, but —

HG: Which recording?

MR: It was just focused on you and you had all these flurry of chords going by and I couldn't tell if you were setting up the group or if this was the actual composition. I'm not really expecting you to —

HG: Yeah I was setting it up. I don't play the head until after my exposition you know, in front. I'm playing on the changes and stuff you know, and the guys recognize it. I don't even have to tell them what I'm doing. As a matter of fact I don't even announce the tunes to them anymore, I just start playing. Because I don't know what I'm going to do next you know.

MR: Your intuition will tell you.

HG: Yes. There was one night we were playing at — with my West Coast trio which is my touring band. We were playing at the Blue Note in New York, a gorgeous nine foot Bosendorfer piano. First set the place was packed, I sit down at the piano, I'm looking at it and I'm thinking oh my God, I've got nothing but options! Nothing but options! What do I do? Since I couldn't decide anything I just started playing and everything went fine. I could have done, I could have done anything at that moment. I had nothing but options.

MR: And that was a positive thing for you then.

HG: Yes.

MR: Okay.

HG: To play without intention. Without imposing yourself on the music, letting the music come out and be what it is. It takes a lot of balls.

MR: It does. And I have had students — and I have felt this way myself — that there are so many things to choose from that that makes it more difficult.

HG: It makes it easier, let the intuition choose. Trust your intuition, it's never wrong. What is there you could say about your life and yourself as a person that's always right? The limbic system is making decisions in a split, a pico. It's making billions of decisions every picosecond. Billions. It's so fast you can't even think about it, the conscious brain cannot handle that. It cannot handle all that information — the amount of information the body processes when it's awake and when it's asleep it's incalculable. It's always assessing the situation constantly, monitoring, putting information, codifying things. It's constant. It never stops. But you can't — the brain can't tolerate that amount of information so it doesn't give you conscious access to it. All those decisions are kept

below the level of consciousness. Too much information, you can't handle it consciously. Only the lower brain can do it. Alligator brain.

MR: Is there such a thing as a mistake in improvising for you?

HG: I used to practice creative mistake making just in case I made a mistake. I used to play wrong purposely just to see how to get out of it.

MR: Okay but if you're playing wrong, I think we're going in a circle here. If you're playing wrong on purpose but you don't maybe call it a mistake you just call it a —

HG: Something else, yeah.

MR: Something else. An avenue to get where I want to go. Oh my. You are a fount of fascinating theories and opinions, I'll say that Hal.

HG: The opinions, at least they're considered opinions. Because a lot of this stuff isn't necessary factual yet because all the science has been on the Western part of the music. Note choice. How does the brain pick a particular note? It's totally bogus. It's the rhythm that picks the notes. That's the African part. And there's hardly any neurological studies on the African part of the music. None. The rhythm, the beat. What is that? How does a beat go through the air and make people tap their feet? You know. What is it? What's the quality? I think I figured it out. I think I figured out what groove is, but I'm not a scientist enough to be able to prove it, and I've done so much research on this fucking book — sorry — on this book, that I'm researched out and I really can't do any more on it, I've got to leave it up to other people who might be interested in following it up. But I've discovered some — like A-A-B, the A-A-B format, all right? You listen to a lot of jazz solos you hear [scats] A [scats] B. Why? Why B? When you play A you hit the expecting part of the brain expects A again, and you play A again. That sets a pattern. The predictive part of the brain then is expecting A a third time but you don't play A a third time, you use A2 as a bridge the third time into A3 and your solo takes off. It's magical. I've been doing it all my life and I didn't realize it until I discovered this like early last year. A-A-B. Idea-Idea creates a problem. When you interrupt the two A's and you don't do A3, you have a problem that needs to be solved and you improvise the solution.

MR: While you're describing that it reminds me of blues lyrics.

HG: Yes. It's the blues form.

MR: Yeah.

HG: That form is throughout the music. Listen to Bird. Listen to swing players. I'm not even sure — I'll tell you this I wasn't aware I was doing it but I've been doing it all my career because I've been copying guys who did that, without knowing why. It's amazing. It has to do with the predictive parts of the brain, the thing that keeps one interested in the music is surprise. It has to be surprised. You have to be surprised as a player. All right?

You don't want to be predictive. It's to surprise you, otherwise it's not going to surprise the audience.

MR: And who was it that said jazz is the sound of surprise?

HG: Yes. Exactly.

MR: Yeah.

HG: So you do A, you do A2, you're expecting A3 but you just take a little bit of A2 and go off with it and next thing you know you've got a line. And it takes off and it has a life of its own. It's almost magical. I had the good fortune to spend a week with Dizzy Gillespie when he was a guest for Phil's band. We toured a week with him. I was never the same after that. Dizzy totally turned me around to realize the rhythmic basis, he said, "Hal, Bird invented the melodies, I invented the rhythm." And his legacy, Mike Longo, you're familiar with Mike Longo — he just passed away. He's the one that has been preserving Dizzy's rhythmic legacy. He's got three DVDs out that are mind-blowing about the rhythm. And since my time with Dizzy I've been focusing almost exclusively on rhythm. Not note choice. Because what happens is the music's going by too fast to choose notes tone by tone. But the rhythm has pressure to it and the rhythm presses you into action. It's called selective pressure. I'm not explaining myself well. It's too big a subject for me to sit here and talk about it, it would take up all this time. Okay so say you play a first note. How do you decide your second note? What decides the second note? The rhythm. You have 496 million possibilities of the chromatic scale within the octave. How do you pick the second note? You know? That was the question. It's done through surprise. It's done unexpected. You break a pattern, it needs to be solved. The brain has a natural intensity to seek equilibrium all the time. Something wrong happens to the body it immediately starts working to get equilibrium. It cannot stand tension, it wants to resolve tension. When you create — that's tension-release, tension-release. That's the whole process right there. A and B. It's an amazing concept. I don't have the scientific underpinnings to back it up but it works. And you're right, I have opinions but I'm one of the last of the apprenticeship system. So the stuff that I'm talking about I've experienced and I just happen to have the facility luckily to be able to talk about it well but — what can I — the rhythmic part of the thing — like Dizzy said the more upbeats in the music the more it swings. And there's a tremendous concern about how musicians deal with the upbeat these days, because they don't know how to deal with it. And Barry Harris used to talk about it, Dizzy talked about it. Dizzy said, "Well if the quarter notes are a continuum then the upbeats have to be a continuum." So I don't know, wait a minute. So I've been working on feeling the beat as a shuffle [scats] try to get it that way. Try to figure out ways to deal with it.

HG: Yeah. But I'm feeling it on the off-beats, not the downbeats. And what's interesting is there's a whole nother world on the offbeat side. It's just a completely different world. Things sound completely different. I didn't realize this but I was at my old lady's loft a few months ago and she had put on Miles' "Relaxin'" album, which was mother's milk to me when I was young so I knew every solo by heart. And I'm listening to this Miles solo but I realized I was listening to it from the offbeat/upbeat side of the beat. And it sounded completely different. I never heard it that way in my life, which makes me realize I haven't been hearing what I've been hearing correctly all or most of my life.

MR: Do you think Miles — how do I ask this?

HG: He comes out of Dizzy. You know he got it from Dizzy.

MR: Okay.

HG: Dizzy was the one — and Mike Longo, the work he's done in preserving his legacy is just mind blowing, historic, should be preserved, and those DVDs should be on every jazz musician's shelf. There's stuff on there I never heard of. Moody's triplet. Moody's triplets. I still don't understand, even though Mike explained it. You know.

MR: Well you mentioned something in passing, that one of the last generations that enjoyed or employed the apprenticeship —

HG: System. Yeah.

MR: System in jazz. And this is a broad question but when you reflect back on let's say the mid-60s into the mid-70s, if you can think back of how you felt about jazz, what you observed about jazz, and if you look at jazz now, let's say in this century, do you think there are major differences for you?

HG: For me? What do you mean for me?

MR: You were involved in this music when the club scene was different, the recording scene was different, and now things have their own way of being in the jazz world. I guess I'm asking what do you think has changed significantly and that it affects the music the most?

HG: Lack of understanding of the rhythm. Because everything is focused on note choice.

MR: Is that because of jazz education?

HG: Yeah. They can sell that. You can't sell the rhythm. But they can sell information.

MR: Well said. That's a good point. You can't justify a four year jazz program by just or focusing on the rhythm I don't think. The pedagogy won't sustain.

HG: That speaks to the system then. I have my own — I came up with my own system. What they did is they destroyed it. The white people who run the academia there destroyed music. Destroyed jazz. You've got these older white men making all these decisions about music that really comes from a black culture. And this is a really — I'm on my soapbox on this because traditionally people talk about information and process. Right?

So you learn the information in school, you learn how to use it in the apprenticeship system. All right? That's the only place to learn is the apprenticeship system. You have to play the stuff. You have to try it out and you have to be playing with a master. You can't — David Baker said, "You don't learn anything playing with your peers." You have to play — and all the masters that I played with, apprenticed with, they all had awe. They were awesome. And if they told you do something you stood up and saluted and did it whether you understood it or not, and sometimes it took you ten years to understand what they told you to do, but they never explained anything. The reason being is they needed you to figure it out yourself because the oral tradition is based on one premise, development of personal voice. That is not part of the educational system, the development of personal voice. But the oral tradition — there are 6,700 different oral tradition, non English oral traditions in the world. It's been around for — I mean the first song flute was 20,000 years old. You know music has been around, unwritten, for 20,000 years. And the Gutenberg Bible screwed all that up because now they could print music and see the notes and make it symbols instead of real sounds. And they get the symbols — it's symbols you know. They give the symbols value. It's the sound that has value. So the third leg that's missing is the culture and that has to do with your question. It's the culture, music always expresses the culture of the moment. And the culture at the time that I was coming up doesn't exist anymore. It's completely fragmented. That has weakened the music tremendously. It's fragmented. Everybody's on their own going for the — nobody's listening to themselves. And I've even heard at New School the students frown on you if you swing. So it's the culture that's missing. The culture that exists now does not support the music. It's the culture. I mean there's a stratification of the culture as well as stratification of the music which both work at the same time. You're on a certain level, all right, you don't talk to the people on the next level. I can't think of a time I initiated a conversation with a master. I never did. They talked to me. You didn't talk to a master because they were somewhere else. Their concerns had nothing to do with your existence. You're down here at level three and they're up at level ten. You can talk to level four maybe, and maybe get a little something from level five. And the same thing is happening socially in the black culture. You're not supposed to bypass anybody. Obama really pissed off the black community in Chicago when he ran against their older black favorite. He jumped over him to get this position on a commission or something and it really pissed off the community because the tradition is you don't skip a level. You earn it. You don't get to the next level until you've done the work to get to it, and then your work gets recognized and you're on the next level with a whole new set of different questions and a whole set of different answers and you don't even know that there's

the next level and there's a whole different set of questions and answers. It just never stops. And there's a musical structure that goes right along with it. That's how the discipline was kept. The masters kept the discipline. There's no discipline anymore. If you didn't do something right — I was playing in a house band with Sonny Stitt, amazing gig for two weeks. He didn't like what the drummer was doing and made him play up on the bell for two weeks. His arm is out like that for two weeks, killing him. They penalize you. If you didn't do something right, you didn't do what they said, they penalized you until you got it together. So they beat you up physically, I mean musically. Usually that's what happened they just crushed you, you know, they were just so great. Phil — Phil could just crush me in a second. I'm an ant next to him. I will never do fours or exchanges with Phil. I did it once, never again, never again. He just blew me out of the water you know. That's something for later on, maybe I'll get that together you know. It's an interesting thing. That cultural support is missing. That's the problem here. Process orientation and the culture. That's the situation.

MR: Do you feel like you've done your best to alleviate that? Because I watched a number of your videos and you were being the master in these situations with college students. It may seem like a small thing against the culture that is happening now but I guess I'm just trying to say that I appreciate that you share your considered opinions.

HG: Some people don't. Ahmad doesn't tell. Ahmad is the godfather as far as I'm concerned but he doesn't tell. Red Garland doesn't tell. What's his name — oh man Hank Jones.

MR: Hank Jones, yeah.

HG: We were playing to a festival in France that had made a bunch of different outdoor stages and Hank Jones was playing and I was at stage — my eyes were at stage level and I could see his feet. And he was pumping the pedals while he was playing but I couldn't hear what he was doing or what pedals he was pumping. So after he got off the set I says, "Hey man, Hank, what were you doing with your pedals man?" And he says, "Oh just trying to keep my feet busy." He wouldn't tell me. Sam Rivers, that was another thing. I apprentice with Sam for six years. He was my post-graduate work. And he was a good friend of mine. Before he came to town there was this rumor about his practice books. In those days we had practice books. There were no published books. 1955? Nothing. So everybody at Berklee had two books. Had a hot lick book and a practice book where they wrote out their exercises and stuff in all twelve keys. Well rumors about Sam Rivers' practice books were rife around town. And when he came back to town we hooked up immediately and we were of like minds. We didn't like anybody. Boston was too conservative. You know. I was playing free on tunes, he was playing free on tunes, we just hooked up. We were just right on the same wavelength. Okay, one afternoon I'm up

which means a long hallway with rooms off the side. One end was the kitchen, the other was the living room. So I'm up in his apartment one day and he's walking up and down the hallway practicing. I'm waiting for him for some reason, I don't remember. He gets all the way down to the kitchen and I look up and I see on top of the piano these three green covered books. I said man, are those his practice books? So I waited until the horn was way down by the kitchen, I could hear the horn get softer and softer, and I got up and I grabbed the books off and started memorizing pages while I'm hearing Sam's horn get louder and louder as he's walking down the hallway towards the living room. He gets to the living room door and he sees me with the books in my lap and he goes — he takes the horn out of his mouth and said "Aha" and runs over and tears them out of my hands. I says, "Sam, man, how come you don't want to share this stuff with me?" He says, "I worked hard for this stuff. Get your own." He wouldn't tell. But I learned so much from Sam anyway. I mean he taught me a lot.

MR: Wow, well Mr. Galper, this is more than I had hoped for.

HG: I'm glad to hear that.

MR: Well you have a unique outlook and — musically and from a philosophy standpoint and I really appreciate you sharing it.

HG: I share it with everybody.

MR: Well good.

HG: I'm not afraid to give my stuff away.

MR: I'm glad to be part of the —

HG: It's my stuff and I'm ahead of you on it.

MR: Well thanks again.

HG: I've really enjoyed this. I really enjoyed this, it was really a fun interview, I have to say that.

MR: Thank you.

HG: Good questions.

MR: I'll sign off and then we'll say our good-byes.

HG: All right so this will be up on YouTube?

MR: Yeah. In a week or so.

HG: All right let me know.

MR: I will.

HG: And I'll take it down and add it to my collection.